MEMBER GUIDES · C6B

Your year as Inner Guard

The first office with a part of the ceremony that is yours. A short guide to what the Inner Guard does, what to learn, and who will help.

For	The Brother about to be invested as Inner Guard, and his Personal Mentor
Issue	Issue 1 (Draft for Review), October 2026 · One of six Officer Guides, Steward to Senior Warden. The office is described here; the words and floorwork are learned at the Lodge of Instruction, never from a document.

1 What the office is

The Inner Guard sits just inside the door of the Lodge room. His job is to see that only those entitled to be present come in: he answers the Tyler's knocks, reports to the Lodge, admits visiting Brethren on the Director of Ceremonies' word, and receives the candidate at the door in the form the ceremony requires. He works under the direction of the Junior Warden and alongside the Tyler, and he is the first officer a candidate meets on the night that matters most to him.

Your jewel	Two swords in saltire. Your tools for the ceremonies are kept at the door; the Tyler and the DC will show you which is which.

2 What you will actually do

- Arrive early and check the door with the Tyler: the knocks you will hear, the tools you will need for the degree being worked, and how your Lodge handles late arrivals.

- Learn the reports: short, formal, and the same every meeting. Practise them until they come without thinking.
- Learn what happens at the door for each of the three degrees, and the difference between admitting a visitor and receiving a candidate.
- Watch the Junior Warden; your cue often comes from him.
- On a candidate's night, remember what the door felt like from his side. A calm Inner Guard steadies a nervous man.

3 What to learn, and how

- Your pieces are short, which is why this office exists first. Get them word-perfect and then work on delivering them with confidence rather than speed.
- Ask the DC or the Preceptor to run the door with you at the Lodge of Instruction before your first meeting in office.
- Begin the Junior Deacon's work during the second half of your year. It is the first office with real learning, and a head start matters.
- Little and often. Ten minutes a day, out loud, beats an hour on the night before.
- Understand it before you memorise it. Words that mean something stay; words that are only sound go under pressure.
- Record it and listen in the car. Then record yourself and listen to that.

4 Things nobody tells you

- The Inner Guard is the officer most likely to be caught by a late arrival mid-ceremony. Ask the DC now what your Lodge does, so that you are not improvising.
- Your Personal Mentor should sit as near you as custom allows for your first meeting or two. Ask him.
- Kneeling is not obligatory for candidates and Jewish Brethren stand covered: if you are told of an adjustment, it is not your decision, it is the DC's and the candidate's.

5 The time it takes

One meeting a month in the season and the Lodge of Instruction most weeks it runs. Perhaps a quarter of an hour a day of learning in the weeks before a ceremony. Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.

6 Who will help

Your Personal Mentor	Still yours. Office does not end mentoring; it changes the conversation. Tell him if the learning is not going well, or the diary.
The Director of Ceremonies	Owns the ceremonies and the floor. He will tell you what your Lodge does, which is what matters; Lodges differ.
The Preceptor and the Lol	Where the office is learned. Go even in the weeks when there is nothing for you to do.
The Lodge Mentor	Watches the office queue for the whole Lodge: nobody pushed before he is ready, nobody left waiting. Say so to him if either is happening to you.
The Province	mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk, the monthly mentoring call on the first Tuesday at 7pm, and Solomon (solomon.ugle.org.uk), which has a paper on every office.

7 Looking ahead

Junior Deacon. It is the first office that takes real learning, so your Lodge Mentor and the DC will want to know by the spring whether you feel ready for it next year. Both answers are allowed.

> **For your mentor.** Three questions for the conversation before the Installation: Does he want this office this year, and has he said so to his family? What is the one piece he is worried about, and who will help him with it? What will we do together in the second half of the year to make the next office feel easy?
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> **Readiness, not pressure, in either direction.** Nobody should take an office before he feels able, and nobody capable should be left waiting. Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.

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